

Horseshoe Girl and Hermit Boy

A Full-Length Play

By David Quang Pham

Logline: In small town Maine, a Vietnamese exchange student summons a river spirit that turns her host sibling into a hermit crab and must send it home before the curse becomes permanent.

Contact:
616 818 5413
david@flavorpictures.com
512 W 158th St #2 New York, New York 10032



CAST OF CHARACTERS

CÁT LÝ, 16, is a Vietnamese girl in Splake High school's 2018 exchange program in Bangor, Maine. Despite being born in 2002, she's not a horse girl. She's instead a proud *horseshoe crab* girl obsessed with arthropods. But in America, this is her chance to transform herself to fit in, so it upsets her to be hosted by an Asian family out of all people. She is passionate and intelligent, but also headstrong and easily frustrated.

MORGAN TRAN, 16, is an Indonesian American boy living with his adoptive parents in Bangor, Maine. Orphaned by the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami, he was found washed up with a Nautilus shell and now wears it in its memory. His desire is to find his birth family and hometown in Indonesia; a yearning he held despite being happily adopted. He is a Splake High School junior. He is solitary and pessimistic, but his soft side enjoys patterns.

ERIC HOAI TRAN, 44, is Morgan Tran's adoptive dad and a former Navy serviceman like his adoptive family, the Nybergs. He was a South Vietnamese orphan during Operation Babylift in 1975. He's picking up Vietnamese. He has a soft yet stoic presence.

SYBIL MA, 44, is Morgan Tran's adoptive mom and a marine engineer who makes the two-hour commute to Bath Iron Works shipyard. She is a third-generation Chinese American but only understands English. She is poised and devoted to her projects.

BAGADUCE, ∞, is a spirit in limbo inside a horseshoe crab shell. As an unphased living fossil, they enjoy turning people into shells of their former selves. They are driven by a desire to reach the spiritual realm. They can be voice only and doubled.

Doubled: Horse Girl / Pet Store Employee / Dr. Heather Baxter

Voice Only: Trainer / Coast Guard

SYNOPSIS

Horseshoe Girl and Hermit Boy tells the story of an arthropod-obsessed Vietnamese exchange student Cát Lý, who stays with the Tran family in 2018 Bangor, Maine. Their adopted son Morgan was orphaned after a tsunami in Indonesia. One day, the teens find a horseshoe crab shell in Bagaduce River, whose spirit transforms Morgan into a hermit crab. They have one day to get this spirit to Relic Island before the curse becomes permanent. The drama-comedy play explores growth, the power of belonging, and the idea that family is built on love not blood.

ACT I

SCENE 1

BANGOR INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT

It is a bright chaotic August day.

16-year-old CÁT LÝ, enters alone wearing a horse-graphic shirt, a 2018 exchange program lanyard, and a backpack. She holds a sign that reads "Nyberg." She is focused and overwhelmed by the idea of *Maine*.

SYBIL MA and her husband ERIC TRAN enter, searching anxiously. Eric holds a sign that reads "Cát Lý."

SYBIL

Horse shirt... Horse shirt... Horse...

ERIC

We've past a dozen horse girls.

SYBIL

Search an image of her.

ERIC

You know every Vietnamese person has a thousand others with the same name.

SYBIL

That's a one-syllable language problem.

Cát puzzledly spots Eric's sign.

CÁT

(Soliloquizing)

Troi đất ơi (Viet: "Oh my god"). You got to be joking me. They promised me an authentic American experience. Those who'll nickname me Cathy cause they can't say Cát Lý. Out of all the families, I get...

(Back to reality)

Nybergs?

SYBIL

(sarcastically to Eric)

Setting a good impression by correcting names.
Cát. This is my husband Eric.

ERIC

Xin chào. I'm Eric "Nyberg." Nyberg is my adoptive family's legal name. But I've taken back Tran. Sybil kept Ma.

The couple walks Cát to the car.

SYBIL

I'm the Ma. Yes. Welcome to Maine.

CÁT

(Formal and rehearsed)

Good day, Mr. Tran and Mrs... Ma. It is an honor to make your acquaintance. I am Cathy.

They drive. Cát sits in the back, looking out at pines and granite.

ERIC

Nhìn gì?

CÁT

Nothing. I much prefer you speak English.

Cát takes out her phone and texts.

CÁT (CONT'D)

(to herself)

Dear Exchange Program Coordinator. I wish to report an error. My host family is Asi-

ERIC

By the way, our son is excited to meet you. He's a bit of a hermit.

SYBIL

The word is *introvert*.

Cát sighs and puts away the phone.

CÁT

This family needs friends.

Fade to black.

SCENE 2

THE TRAN HOUSE

The house is cozy as can be with a living room and bedrooms.

SYBIL

That will be your room.

ERIC

Bathroom's there with fresh towels.

CÁT

Water here might be amazing. Thank you lots,
Eric and Mrs. Ma.

SYBIL

Right.

ERIC

Your new classmate is here!

MORGAN TRAN steps out, headphones
on his head and a special Nautilus
shell necklace around his neck.

A beat as the teens lock eyes.

CÁT

A pleasure to meet you, Morgan. I've got
Indonesian / klepon for you

MORGAN

/ No need. Mom - dad's making salmon tonight.

Holding his necklace tight, Morgan
hides away in his room.

SYBIL

Morgan. / Ăn đòn không, muốn ăn đòn không
(Viet: "Do you want a beating?")?!

CÁT

/ You said he's adopted from Indonesia, right?
/ Tiếng Việt của bạn hay quá (Viet: "Your
Vietnamese is so good"), Mrs. Ma.

ERIC

Sorry, Cát. / He's a hermit.

SYBIL

Cam on, Cathy. / Introvert.

ERIC

It'll take time for him to warm up to you.

CÁT

(Soliloquizing)

It takes forever to warm up an *absolute zero*.

Cát unpacks her clothes, many
deliberately plain shirts and
jeans in hopes of blending in. She
finds that her parents has packed
her horseshoe crab shirt as well.

CÁT (CONT'D)

I'll keep it 100. This semester would go bad for horseshoe girl Cát Lý. But not horse girl Cathy.

Cát throws the horseshoe crab shirt in the trash. She wears a horse hoodie and stiff jeans.

SCENE 3

HORSE RANCH

By the stable yard fence, Cát stands nervously with the previous clothes, an attempt to seem cool.

HORSE GIRL enters, looking fabulous in their boots.

CÁT

I am a horse girl. Not a horseshoe girl...

HORSE GIRL

Did you adjust the saddle fit on Curless? The bridging be off yesterday.

CÁT

Bridging? Saddle fit? Half-pad? *Equus ferus caballus*... This is harder than Latin.

TRAINER (OFFSTAGE)

Cát... Um lie? Lee?

CÁT

Call me Cathy!

Cát walks off.

Morgan walks past the stables with a sketchbook in hand. He draws.

MORGAN

Cát's trying to be a cowgirl... Haha, so sad.

TRAINER (OFFSTAGE)

Fix your posture! Heels down! Relax them hips!

CÁT (OFFSTAGE)

Relaxing hard! Relax ah! Troi đất oi (Viet: "Oh my god")!

We hear Cát fall off the horse.

Horse Girl runs off. Morgan seems embarrassed. He goes to his car.

HORSE GIRL (OFFSTAGE)

How are you making out?

CÁT (OFFSTAGE)

What...?

HORSE GIRL (OFFSTAGE) (CONT'D)

You okay?

Horseshoe Girl helps Cát walk in
and reach Morgan.

CÁT (CONT'D)

I don't belong on this soil...

HORSE GIRL

Neither do me nor my buddy. We've got quirks.
You just gotta find where you fitting. Morgan,
you're actually getting outta the house.

MORGAN

She's my host sister and I have to babysit her.

Horse Girl helps Cát get into
Morgan's car. They drive off.

MORGAN (CONT'D)

Still trying to be a cowgirl?

CÁT

Horse girl. They're a specific subspecies. Hard
to communicate.

MORGAN

Subspecies- I've not heard you talk that way.

CÁT

I fell on my head real hard. / *Ham chôi thì vua
vua thối chu...*

MORGAN

/ Let's head home and get that checked out.

Cát sees the sketchbook. It is an
abstract pattern drawing that
embodies Cát and the horse.

CÁT

I need to change...

MORGAN

You don't need to change. Your headspace just
needs the right environment.

Fade to black.

SCENE 4

BAGADUCE RIVER

It is a cloudy September day.

By the rocky algae-covered banks,
Cát and Morgan walk along it.

CÁT

The tidal range is amazing. Two meters. In
Haiphong, we get half that. I wonder why.

MORGAN

Ma can explain this when she gets off her call.

CÁT

Life as a marine engineer must be fun.

MORGAN

Today's actually a fun day for her. A phone
call instead of driving two hours to Bath Iron.

CÁT

Maine has the weirdest names. *Bath Iron. Lubec.*
Towns named *Sweden, Mexico. Damariscotta.*

He stops and picks up something.

MORGAN

You're weird.

CÁT

Says the hermit.

MORGAN

It's no hermit. *It's your thing.*

He shows a horseshoe crab shell.

CÁT

EEEEEEK! A LIMULUS POLYPHEMUS!
(Recomposing herself)
That's not my thing.

MORGAN

No one in the house wears animal shirts.

CÁT

You dug through trash?

MORGAN

Your horseshoe crab shirt stuck out, okay. It's
your thing.

He hands her the shell. The first time they've genuinely connected.

CÁT

It's... beautiful. The size. The condition. I'm surprised as they haven't spawned for months.

MORGAN

I can find shells any time. I'm okay at that.

CÁT

Where did you find Nautilus? Those are rare.

MORGAN

I got it when I was little...

CÁT

The tsunami. I'm sorry.

MORGAN

I don't remember- I just remember this shell. Rescuers found me washed up with it. It's my good-luck shell. The one memory of my family.

Sybil enters, done with a call.

SYBIL

Another find? Alright. The weather looks like it's going to get out of hand. Let's head home.

They head into their car.

MORGAN

Can you explain how these tides are tides?

SYBIL

That's the first.

MORGAN

It's for Cát.

SYBIL

Makes sense.

Time passes. It is now raining. Cát and Morgan sit in the back as Sybil drives. They're nearly home.

RADIO (V.O.)

A powerful earthquake rocked the island of Sulawesi today, triggering a 10-foot-tall tsunami that swept away houses-

Sybil parks the car and switches the key off.

SYBIL

Salmon is spawning and warm inside.

Sybil gets out of the car.

The breaking news breaks their connection. Too much for Morgan.

CÁT

Morgan?

He puts on his headphones and turns up his music. He quickly gets out of the car and heads to the house, sealing himself off.

Cát looks at the horseshoe shell then her exchange program lanyard.

CÁT (CONT'D)

Head home to your shell. He's a hermit with nowhere to go. I have nowhere to go. Maybe, we both are lost here.

SCENE 5

THE TRAN HOUSE

It is past bedtime. Lights up on the doorway to Morgan's bedroom. Eric goes to it.

ERIC

I don't think it's a good idea to eat salmon, especially around a bed.

Cát enters brushing her teeth.

ERIC (CONT'D)

Where does a hermit go when they got no shell?

CÁT

(Mouth full)

They die?

ERIC

No, they find a bigger shell. Whatever he's going through, he's a bigger man in the end.

Eric goes off to bed.

Cát gets the horseshoe shell.

CÁT

We're both orphaned in this country. I am by choice, briefly abandoning my home. He is by tragedy, searching for... home?

Cát holds the horseshoe shell up.

CÁT (CONT'D)

I wish we could both feel at home. I wish for Morgan to be a bigger man in the end.

Cát turns off the light and rests.

Black out.

ACT II

SCENE 1

THE TRAN HOUSE

It is the morning of October 23.

A sudden snowstorm rages outside.

The landline phone rings. Cát wakes up and picks it up.

CÁT

Whattttttt's upppppp?

SYBIL (V.O.)

The snow! Roads are awful. Snow in October?!

Cát stares out the window. This is her first time seeing snow.

ERIC (V.O.)

Typical Maine.

CÁT

How is the ship... um?

SYBIL (V.O.)

The ship christening was fantastic.

ERIC (V.O.)

The Nyberg legacy holds strong.

CÁT

Aren't you driving your parents today?

ERIC (V.O.)

That's tomorrow's problem.

SYBIL (V.O.)

Go experience your first snow day without us.

CÁT (V.O.)

It's okay. I can wait til tomorrow.

SYBIL (V.O.)

No no. A school snow day.

ERIC (V.O.)

Check the school app, girrrl.

Cát reads her phone.

CÁT

School's canceled? Where will I go?

SYBIL (V.O.)

Back to bed, dear.

ERIC (V.O.)

We'll see you tomorrow, kiddo.

SYBIL (V.O.)

Wake up Morgan so you can drink your first hot coco too.

ERIC (V.O.)

A hermit's favorite drink I always say.

The landline phone hangs up.

CÁT

How to make a snowball...?

Cát searches on her phone. She goes out and makes a snowball. She heads to Morgan's doorway.

CÁT (CONT'D)

Morning, Morgan. Don't miss the snow! Ra đây cho tao biêu không (*Viet: "Come here and face me"*)-

Cát barges into Morgan's room. It is empty. She finds his necklace abandoned. She picks it up.

CÁT (CONT'D)

Why'd you leave this? You never take it off. You never let me touch it.

A hermit crab pops out of the Nautilus pendant, startling Cát.

CÁT (CONT'D)

Ah, a hermit crab?! Well... wherever you came from, it was probably *somewhere cute*. I can't believe he'd hide you away from me! As a good friend of Bagaduce, I won't keep you away from-

Cát holds the horseshoe shell. It suddenly becomes sentient, causing her to drop them.

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

Me?

CÁT

Ah!! You- you're not coming from anywhere good!

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

I come from the river. I'd say it's good as good can be.

CÁT

Okay, spirit of the river... What I heard about spirits is that you're all knowing.

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

Water knows very little. The spirit of the air is everywhere.

CÁT

Do they know where Morgan Tran is?

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

He is in the shell of his former self.

CÁT

Don't you mean HE'S A shell of his former self?

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

This is no riddle. He's a literal hermit.

CÁT

What's new?

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

Put me on your head...

CÁT

That... would be.

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

Trust me.

Cát wears Bagaduce on her head.

A life-sized Morgan could reappear in a horseshoe crab costume or he could remain voice-overed.

MORGAN

Do not trust them!

CÁT

No no no. It's not possible. But then... everything eventually evolves into a crab...

MORGAN

CATHY!

CÁT

Okay, don't get your shells in a twist. How...?

MORGAN

I don't know! I lied in bed, saw snow, then-

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

You saw the moon too right?

MORGAN

Yes, the moon.

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

Just making sure it ain't a mistake.

MORGAN

I wished I could hide forever then poof! Next thing I knew, fingerless. Spineless-

CÁT

No change there.

Morgan pinches Cát.

CÁT (CONT'D)

Ow! The pincers are wicked cool. And you can't be cool. Turn him back, Bagaduce!

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

Change is hard when you are a living fossil.

MORGAN

Could you have at least made me fit in my Nautilus shell. It's so loose...

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

You'll grow into it.

CÁT

But you changed him last night...

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

With the help of the nearly full moon.

CÁT

Another one is tonight. We can wait. I can find a board game your size, Morgan.

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

You must go to Relic Island!

CÁT

Have you heard of this board game, Morgan?

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

It is where you call upon the spirits to take me home.

MORGAN

I think it's a real place...

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

You must reach the island and *spark a light stronger than a hunter's full moon* or you stay a hermit forever.

MORGAN

Forever?!

Cát researches on her phone.

CÁT

That's tonight! I cannot seem to find where...
Where is Relic Island?

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

I don't know. You've got them opposable thumbs.
So get moving.

CÁT

You got ten legs...

BAGADUCE (V.O.)

I'm just a voice in a shell, kid...

MORGAN

And I've got ten too...

CÁT

We've twenty hours.

MORGAN

I can't drive with these.

CÁT

I still got my hands.

MORGAN

Even if you had your license, snow's heavy.

CÁT

Let's wait until it melts.

Morgan sighs.

CÁT (CONT'D)

Mày tuong mày nói chuyện voi ai vậy (Viet: "Who do you think you are talking to")? I've survived the roads of Ho Chi Minh City on a scooter. An avalanche is nothing to me.

MORGAN

Besides a new shell that fits me better, I'm gonna probably need a new car after all this.

CÁT

Is the shell hurting?

MORGAN

A single wind might.

CÁT

Copy, Hermit Boy.

Cát grabs the car keys from
Morgan's room and puts on his
winter coat.

CÁT (CONT'D)

Where'd you stash your allowance?

MORGAN

I ain't telling you nothing.

CÁT

The underwear drawer?

MORGAN

Nooooooooooooo!!!!!!

Cát grabs a stash of cash.

CÁT

First stop: the pet store!

Cát safely puts Morgan in her coat
pocket and grabs her backpack.
Bagaduce is still on her head.

They run out into the blizzard.

Fade to black.